

Marginalized Group Career Counseling

Kolby J. Ray

College of Humanities and Social Sciences, Grand Canyon University

CNL-525-O501: Career Counseling

Dr. Jill Willis

July 21, 2025

Marginalized Group Career Counseling

This paper will explore career counseling through the lens of individuals with disabilities. This paper will include an explanation of who this population is and why it is important for them to receive career counseling. In addition, there will be a discussion about the statistics on the group with factors like population size, employment problems, and how many utilize career counseling. This paper will discuss Social Cognitive Career Theory and how it applies to both the general population and those who have disabilities. In addition to discussing the theory, an example will be provided of how to incorporate SCCT in treatment planning. Finally, there will be a discussion on the role of spirituality in career counseling and how it can be impactful throughout the counseling experience.

Individuals with Disabilities

Who are they?

Individuals with disabilities are people who experience short, medium, and long-term physical, mental, intellectual, sensory, or developmental impairments that may limit their full and effective participation in society on a basis of equality with others (Krahn et al., 2015).

Individuals with disabilities have often been overlooked in public health efforts, but more recent initiatives have brought attention to the significant health challenges they face. Compared to those without disabilities, adults with disabilities are much more likely to rate their health as fair or poor (Krahn et al., 2015). Public health aims to improve health outcomes for all groups and is increasingly focused on addressing health disparities. These disparities are generally understood as population-level differences in health that stem from long-standing social, economic, or environmental disadvantages, and are considered preventable (Krahn et al., 2015).

Importance of Career Counseling

People with disabilities often encounter distinct obstacles when trying to enter and succeed in the workforce. As society moves toward greater inclusion, career counseling is increasingly seen as a vital resource in supporting the career growth of individuals with disabilities (Atobatele & Okonkwo, 2025). It provides personalized guidance to help them manage employment-related challenges. Disabilities can take many forms, physical, cognitive, sensory, or psychological, and each type may create different barriers in the workplace (Atobatele & Okonkwo, 2025). Because of this, career counseling plays a key role in building confidence, developing skills, and promoting equal opportunities. By responding to the specific needs of this population, career counseling helps dismantle systemic obstacles and encourages the recognition and inclusion of diverse abilities in professional settings (Atobatele & Okonkwo, 2025).

Statistics of the Group

According to the CDC, in the United States, over one in four adults, about 28.7%, live with some form of disability (2025). These disabilities vary in type and severity: 13.9% have cognitive disabilities that affect concentration, memory, or decision-making; 12.2% experience mobility issues that make walking or climbing stairs difficult; 7.7% face challenges with independent living, such as completing errands alone; 6.2% are deaf or have significant hearing difficulties; 5.5% have vision impairments, even with corrective lenses; and 3.6% struggle with self-care tasks like dressing or bathing (CDC, 2025).

Challenges With Employment

People with disabilities reported experiencing poor employment conditions in many areas (Shahidi et al., 2023). They were more likely to hold temporary or part-time jobs, face job and income instability, engage in gig work, experience wage theft, feel stuck in unsuitable jobs, and

encounter mismatches between their skills and job roles. Additionally, they were less likely to have access to flexible schedules, opportunities for training, or safe and supportive work environments (Shahidi et al., 2023).

Career Counseling Services

As of July 2021, only 19.4% of people with disabilities (PWD) were employed, compared to 64.9% of those without disabilities. To address this gap, the state-federal Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) program, available across all U.S. states and territories, supports PWD in finding and keeping employment (Kaya et al., 2023). This program provides a range of services, such as vocational assessments, job placement, on-the-job support, counseling, job search help, assistive technology, education, training, and post-secondary support (Kaya et al., 2023). These services are designed to assist PWD in preparing for, entering, and maintaining meaningful employment. Individuals who receive SSI or SSDI are generally considered eligible for VR services if they are likely to become employed with the help of these supports (Kaya et al., 2023).

Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT)

Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT), based on Albert Bandura's Self-Efficacy Theory and broader Social Cognitive Theory, presents a detailed framework for understanding career development (Wang et al., 2022). Introduced by Lent and colleagues in 1994, SCCT suggests that a person's career path is shaped by the interaction of various influencing factors (Wang et al., 2022). Social cognitive theory overall emphasizes that individuals are influenced by a continuous interplay between their environment, personal thoughts and feelings, and both past and present behaviors (Wang et al., 2022).

General Population

SCCT emphasizes the impact of both personal and environmental factors on career decision-making by examining how cognitive elements like self-efficacy, outcome expectations, learning experiences, and personal interests shape career development (Wang et al., 2022). According to SCCT, contextual factors shape individuals' career interests and decisions by influencing their learning experiences. These factors are divided into background contextual affordances, which help form interests and self-beliefs, and more immediate contextual influences that directly impact career choices. While these two types of contextual variables sometimes overlap, for example, through family and social influences, they affect a person's academic and career development in different ways at various stages of life (Wang et al., 2022).

SCCT with Individuals with Disabilities

SCCT views disability status as a personal factor that influences career development (Gibbons et al., 2015). It shapes how individuals experience learning, which in turn affects their confidence in career and college abilities, as well as their expectations for outcomes (Gibbons et al., 2015). People with disabilities often face major obstacles such as restricted access to career opportunities, limited information about college and careers, and social discrimination, all of which can make career decision-making more challenging (Gibbons et al., 2015). While traditional career models typically match interests to job options, individuals with intellectual disabilities often require a more tailored and comprehensive approach (Gibbons et al., 2015). SCCT offers a broad perspective on career development by emphasizing self-efficacy and perceived barriers, making it especially helpful for understanding the unique needs of young adults with intellectual disabilities (Gibbons et al., 2015).

A Plan using SCCT

Using Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT) to support a person with a disability involves focusing on enhancing their self-efficacy, outcome expectations, and addressing the environmental barriers they face. Doing so will effectively promote career development (Brown & Lent, 2021). The plan begins with assessing the individual's strengths, interests, and perceived abilities to build confidence in their skills. It would be wise for the counselor to have their client take either the Strong Interest Inventory or another assessment like it to help narrow down their interests. After that, the counselor would then facilitate positive learning experiences, such as internships, job shadowing, or skills training, that is tailored to the person's unique needs and abilities (Brown & Lent, 2021). These experiences are important because they help reinforce self-efficacy and clarify realistic career goals, which is the primary focus of SCCT. While working with the client, the counselor will attempt to identify environmental obstacles, such as accessibility issues, discrimination, or lack of information, by connecting the individual to resources like assistive technology, vocational rehabilitation services, and supportive networks (Gibbons et al., 2015). The plan should also include setting measurable and achievable short- and long-term goals to maintain motivation and track progress. This not only motivates the client but also allows them to see their progress throughout their experience. During this process, the counselor encourages the individual to reflect on their outcome expectations to foster a positive and proactive mindset toward career challenges. This may look different depending on the individual and their unique disability. Using this approach empowers the client by balancing personal choice with practical support, ultimately promoting desired employment outcomes (Gibbons et al., 2015). Research supports the effectiveness of SCCT in addressing the complex interplay of personal and contextual factors influencing career development for people with disabilities (Brown & Lent, 2021).

Potential Barriers

Environmental Factors

Individuals with intellectual disabilities often express that having a job is an important aspect of their lives, and many are interested in regular paid employment (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). Holding a job provides numerous benefits, such as giving individuals a sense of purpose and status, encouraging social engagement, and supporting their inclusion in the community (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). Employment also offers financial independence and is considered a key factor in improving overall well-being, contributing to better health, quality of life, and a stronger sense of personal control. Additionally, working provides opportunities to develop new skills and can boost self-esteem (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). There are environmental factors that make it difficult for individuals with disabilities to find work including lack of resources, pay disparities, and companies being unwilling to adapt to their unique needs (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). Historically, individuals with intellectual disabilities (ID) have had limited access to paid employment, with most vocational services taking place in segregated settings. However, increased focus from the human rights movement on normalization, integration, and deinstitutionalization has shifted societal views and influenced the development of new laws and policies supporting inclusion (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). The importance of workforce participation for people with ID was also reinforced by the United Nations in its 2006 Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). Unfortunately, despite these advancements, a significant gap remains between the employment rates of people with and without disabilities. Current data shows that only a small percentage of individuals with ID, ranging from 9% to 40%, depending on the country, are engaged in some form of paid work (Ellenkamp et al., 2015).

Individual Factors

Many studies have highlighted the significance of personal factors such as motivation, competence, self-determination, and work habits in the employment outcomes of individuals with disabilities (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). Research on school-based programs emphasizes the need for smooth transitions from school to the workforce, along with continued support on the job (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). In addition to personal and educational factors, the surrounding environment plays a crucial role in shaping how individuals with disabilities function. Some studies have explored how social inclusion, natural supports, and community involvement relate to employment in community settings (Ellenkamp et al., 2015). One review identified eleven key elements of social inclusion in employment, with the most common being social roles, personal attributes, and environmental conditions. Frameworks like the International Classification of Functioning, Disability and Health (ICF) and the World Report on Disability also stress the importance of considering both personal and environmental factors when understanding an individual's functioning and participation (Ellenkamp et al., 2015).

Resources

Employment plays a key role in promoting both social sustainability and personal well-being. For individuals with disabilities, securing a job is especially meaningful, as it supports financial independence and encourages greater involvement in social life (Qiu et al., 2023). However, global data shows that the employment rate for people with disabilities is just 44%, compared to 75% for those without disabilities. This substantial gap not only impacts the quality of life for individuals with disabilities but also has broader negative effects on society (Qiu et al., 2023).

Utah State Office of Rehabilitation (USOR)

The Utah State Office of Rehabilitation (USOR) and Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) offer a wide range of employment services designed to support individuals with significant disabilities. These services include supported employment, job coaching, skills training, and access to assistive technology, all aimed at helping individuals secure and maintain competitive, integrated employment (Jobs.utah.gov).

Pre-Employment Transition Services (Pre-ETS)

Pre-Employment Transition Services (Pre-ETS) provide free assistance to students aged 14 to 21, focusing on career exploration, preparing for the workplace, planning for education after high school, gaining hands-on work experience, and building self-advocacy skills. These services are available even to students who are not yet part of the Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) program (Jobs.utah.gov).

Ability 1st Utah Employment Services

Ability 1st Utah Employment Services is part of the Social Security Administration's Ticket to Work program, providing support to individuals receiving SSDI or SSI between the ages of 18 and 64. Their free services include job coaching, help with finding employment, benefits counseling, assistance with resumes and interviews, support with workplace accommodations, and peer advocacy (Jobs.utah.gov).

Recommendations for the Plan

I believe that by using these resources, the intervention plan for clients with disabilities will work. In order for the plan to work, as a counselor, I would have to work closely with the local resources to collaborate a plan of action to help a client find work. I think the best way that a person with disabilities can find work is to allow them to get hands on learning to build their

confidence in specific areas. With these resources in mind, allowing them to find the one that works best for them will allow them to find a job that best fits them.

Spirituality in Career Counseling

Incorporating spirituality into career counseling involves recognizing how a client's beliefs, values, and religious practices shape their sense of purpose, identity, and decision-making (Lemke, 2020). Lemke emphasizes that vocation is not only about job roles but also about finding a deeper sense of meaning, purpose, and spiritual identity across the lifespan (2020). When working with clients from various spiritual backgrounds, such as a Jewish client who observes the Sabbath, it is essential to understand how their faith influences career preferences and constraints (Lemke, 2020). For example, a counselor might help the client explore job opportunities that respect their need of worship within their religion. In addition, the counselor can engage the client in reflection about how their work contributes to their broader sense of spiritual fulfillment, community responsibility, and personal growth (Lemke, 2020).

Conclusion

This paper explored career counseling through the lens of individuals with disabilities. This paper included an explanation of who this population of people is and why it is important for them to receive career counseling. In addition, the statistics on the group with factors like population size, employment problems, and how many utilize career counseling, were also discussed. Through the lens of Social Cognitive Career Theory, this paper identified how it applies to both the general population and those who have disabilities. In addition to discussing the theory, this paper provided an example of how SCCT is relevant in treatment planning. Finally, the role of spirituality in career counseling was addressed and how it can be impactful

throughout the counseling experience because it shapes their values, purpose, and decision-making.

References

- Atobatele, F. A., & Okonkwo, C. A. (2025). The impact of Career Counseling on individuals with disabilities: A Review. *International Journal of Multidisciplinary Research and Growth Evaluation*, 5(1), 1530–1535. <https://doi.org/10.54660/ijmrge.2024.5.1.1530-1535>
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. (n.d.). *Disability impacts all of us infographic*. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. <https://www.cdc.gov/disability-and-health/articles-documents/disability-impacts-all-of-us-infographic.html>
- Ellenkamp, J. J., Brouwers, E. P., Embregts, P. J., Joosen, M. C., & van Weeghel, J. (2015). Work environment-related factors in obtaining and maintaining work in a competitive employment setting for employees with intellectual disabilities: A systematic review. *Journal of Occupational Rehabilitation*, 26(1), 56–69. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10926-015-9586-1>
- Gibbons, M. M., Justina, H., Cihak, D. F., Wright, R., & Mynatt, B. (2015). A social-cognitive exploration of the career and college understanding of young adults with intellectual disabilities. *Professional School Counseling*, 19(1). <https://doi.org/10.5330/1096-2409-19.1.80>
- Kaya, C., Bishop, M., & Torres, A. (2023). The impact of work incentives benefits counseling on employment outcomes: A national vocational rehabilitation study. *Journal of Occupational Rehabilitation*, 33(3), 538–549. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10926-022-10092-1>

- Krahn, G. L., Walker, D. K., & Correa-De-Araujo, R. (2015). Persons with disabilities as an unrecognized health disparity population. *American Journal of Public Health, 105*(S2). <https://doi.org/10.2105/ajph.2014.302182>
- Qiu, N., Jiang, Y., Sun, Z., & Du, M. (2023). The impact of disability-related deprivation on employment opportunity at the neighborhood level: Does family socioeconomic status matter? *Frontiers in Public Health, 11*. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2023.1232829>
- Shahidi, F. V., Jetha, A., Kristman, V., Smith, P. M., & Gignac, M. A. (2023). The Employment Quality of persons with disabilities: Findings from a national survey. *Journal of Occupational Rehabilitation, 33*(4), 785–795. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10926-023-10113-7>
- Supported Employment Services. (n.d.). <https://jobs.utah.gov/usor/vr/services/work.html>
- Wang, D., Liu, X., & Deng, H. (2022). The perspectives of social cognitive career theory approach in current times. *Frontiers in Psychology, 13*. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.1023994>